

Loaded Headline Laboratory Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 25-35 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	loaded-headline-laboratory

Big idea: Wording frames interpretation.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students see how word choice frames knowledge claims.

Student Prompt

Inspect Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A neutral claim rewritten as alarming, heroic, bureaucratic, and sceptical headlines. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Headline cards using verbs such as 'admits', 'claims', 'reveals', and 'warns'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Loaded Headline Laboratory Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A trust rating before and after students see the same evidence. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Wording frames interpretation.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Can language be neutral?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Language.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how wording frames interpretation.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: Can language be neutral?

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A neutral claim rewritten as alarming, heroic, bureaucratic, and sceptical headlines.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- A neutral claim rewritten as alarming, heroic, bureaucratic, and sceptical headlines.
- Headline cards using verbs such as 'admits', 'claims', 'reveals', and 'warns'.
- A trust rating before and after students see the same evidence.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/loaded-headline-laboratory/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/loaded-headline-laboratory/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/loaded-headline-laboratory/visual-prompt.svg>
- Printable student worksheet with observation, inference, evidence, and confidence columns.
- Teacher notes with setup checklist, sample facilitation language, misconceptions, and assessment look-fors.
- Classroom run kit with prompt cards, example stimuli, and debrief moves.
- PowerPoint deck with a student-facing sequence for running the activity.

Run Sequence

1. Groups rewrite the event as a school announcement, tabloid headline, human rights report, police report, student activist post and parent message.
2. The class identifies loaded words, omitted details and implied blame.
3. Students reconstruct the most neutral version possible.
4. Discuss whether complete neutrality is possible.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: Can language be neutral?
- How does word choice affect what we think we know?
- Is objective description possible?

Teacher Quick Script

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...